



CITY TOUR

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RELOCATION GUIDE

Christchurch

Ōtautahi

A relocation guide for healthcare professionals and their families. The work, the neighbourhoods, the money and the weekends in Christchurch.

A flat, friendly, rebuilt city. Mountains and sea on your doorstep.

Christchurch had the rare chance to decide what it wanted to be. Most people arriving now find a flat, green, unusually open city that feels newer than its age, with a serious hospital, a house you can afford and a twenty-minute commute.

~390k

people in the city

~1m

people in the tertiary
catchment

~20 min

typical suburban
commute

90 min

to the nearest ski field

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Guides describe places, not employers. Hospitals are described rather than named, and salaries, visas and registration rules change, so we confirm the detail with you directly.

Why people love Christchurch

People often choose Christchurch for practical reasons: the work, the housing, the commute. What keeps them is everything they discover once they are here.

After the earthquakes of 2010 and 2011, the city reimaged its centre rather than copying the old one. The rebuilt centre is lower, greener and organised around the Ōtākaro Avon rather than turned away from it, with laneways, a riverside promenade and a run of striking new civic buildings.

What that means for you is a city with room in it. Room in the streets, room in the houses, room in the price of things. For a clinician moving with a family, that is often what wins them over.

TERTIARY CENTRE

Rich, varied clinical work

The city's tertiary hospital is one of New Zealand's largest, serving the southern half of the country. The case mix is broad because this is where the region's complex care comes.

NATIONAL AGREEMENTS

Same pay, more breathing room

Your gross salary is identical to Auckland's, and housing costs meaningfully less. That difference goes a long way, and you feel it every month.

FLAT AND GRIDDED

The commute gives you your evening

Twenty minutes across a flat city. People leave work and are home in time for a proper evening.

WEEKENDS, NOT HOLIDAYS

The South Island is the back garden

Ski fields ninety minutes away, surf fifteen, and Queenstown, the lakes and the West Coast inside a day's drive.



The Ōtākaro Avon. The rebuilt centre now faces the river instead of turning away from it.



The Arts Centre, the old university, rebuilt stone by stone.

WHAT YOU GAIN

A major case mix

Complexity and volume well beyond what a city of 400,000 would usually see.

Space and value

The best-value housing of the three main centres, on identical pay.

Time back

Roughly an hour a day compared with Auckland, and mountains or sea at the weekend.

GOOD TO KNOW

Relaxed evenings

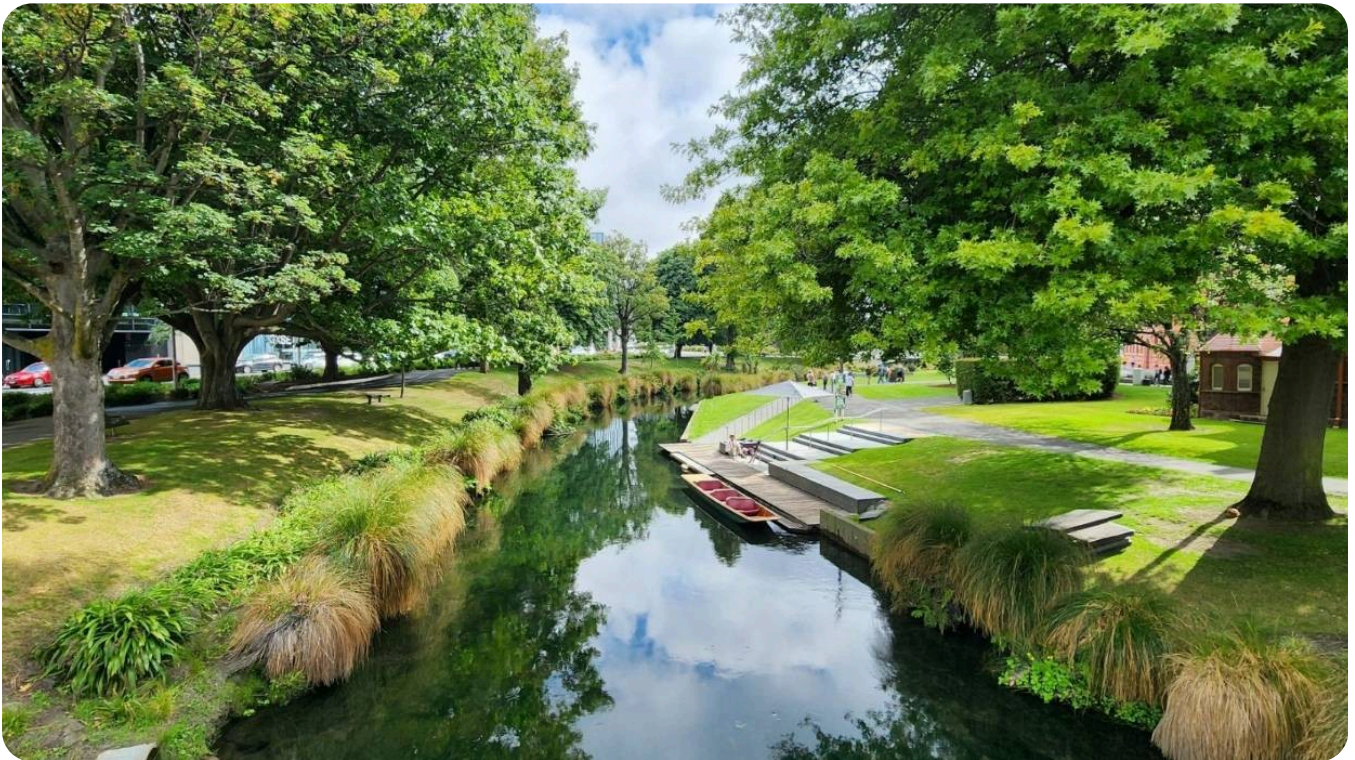
If big late-night and live-music scenes top your list, Wellington or Auckland have more. If you love good bars, restaurants and easy evenings, Christchurch delivers.

A city on the rise

The river, gardens and rebuilt centre are lovely, and new neighbourhoods keep adding life around them.

Flights home

An airport fifteen minutes away, with easy connections to Europe through Auckland, Sydney or Singapore.



Punts on the Ōtākaro Avon. Green space runs right through the middle of the city.

Flat city, big sky, real seasons

Christchurch sits between the Southern Alps and the Pacific on the Canterbury Plains, and that geography explains almost everything about how it feels to live here.

Imagine a grid laid on a plain, with a river running through it, hills at the southern edge and the sea to the east. That is the whole city in one sentence, and it is why Christchurch is such an easy city to find your way around.

The rebuilt centre sits around Cathedral Square and the river, walkable end to end in twenty minutes. The western suburbs are older and leafier. The Port Hills rise to the south, the beaches run along the east, and the satellite towns sit twenty-five to forty minutes out on the plains.



From the Port Hills: the estuary, the eastern suburbs and the long line of the coast.

Summer

DEC – FEB

22–24°C and dry, often 30°C or more on nor'west days. Light until nine in the evening.

Autumn

MAR – MAY

16–19°C, settled and clear. The local favourite.

Winter

JUN – AUG

10–12°C. Frosty mornings, still air, bright afternoons. Snow settling in the city is rare.

Spring

SEP – NOV

15–18°C, changeable, and the windiest stretch of the year.

This is the most continental climate of New Zealand's main centres. Two things delight arrivals. Winter mornings are crisp and clear, with frost on the car from June. And the days that follow are still, cloudless and bright: a proper winter with blue skies.

The one piece of weather to know about is the nor'wester, a hot, dry wind that crosses the Alps and arrives on the plains warm and desiccated. It brings the hottest days of summer, a good excuse for the beach, and plenty of good-humoured local grumbling.

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A note for home buyers

Nearly all of the central city and a large share of housing is post-2011, built to current standards. Land in parts of the east was returned to open space. Renters rarely need to think about it. If you buy, an engineer's report and a look at the insurance and repair history are standard local practice, and give good peace of mind.



Worcester Boulevard in summer. The centre is flat, compact and easy on foot.

Healthcare and work in Christchurch

The city's tertiary hospital is one of the largest in New Zealand, and it serves the southern half of the country. That combination is the clinical reason most people come.

~1m

people in the catchment

From roughly Blenheim to Invercargill

Half

of the country served

The southern half, by geography

Same

pay as Auckland

National collective agreements

Everything public here is delivered by Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora. If a complex case arises anywhere from Blenheim to Invercargill, this is generally where it comes. Retrieval and transfer are routine parts of the job in a way they are not in Auckland, where another tertiary centre is usually a short drive away.

Practically, you see more, you see it earlier, and you are more often the definitive answer rather than a step on the way to one. Clinicians moving from large urban systems in the UK, South Africa or the Gulf tend to describe it as a step up in responsibility rather than down in complexity.

CENTRAL CAMPUS

The tertiary centre

Acute, surgical, specialist and emergency services for the wider South Island, a short walk from Hagley Park.

BESIDE THE MAIN CAMPUS

Women's and newborn services

Specialist maternity, neonatal and gynaecology services, adjacent to the central hospital.

NORTH-EAST

A rehabilitation campus

Nationally significant rehabilitation, spinal and older persons' health services.

MERIVALE AND THE CENTRE

Private hospitals

Mostly planned surgery, endoscopy and diagnostics, five to ten minutes from the central campus. Many senior clinicians work across both sectors.

PLAINS AND HIGH COUNTRY

Rural Canterbury

Rural hospitals and community services.
Generalist work, real autonomy, and for many the part of a Canterbury career they enjoy most.

Because the city is flat and compact, working across the public and private sectors is unusually practical. A public list in the morning and a private list a few minutes north in the afternoon is a short drive rather than a lost half-day. For theatre nurses, anaesthetic technicians, radiographers and sonographers, the private sector is a substantial employer in its own right.

Worth knowing before you apply

- ✓ Registration is national, not regional. The process is the same wherever in New Zealand you work.
- ✓ Rural and provincial Canterbury rotations exist in several specialties.
- ✓ Enrol your household with a GP as soon as you have an address. Popular practices fill quickly, so an early start helps.
- ✓ Plenty of staff cycle to the central campus, which saves hunting for a park.
- ✓ If cross-sector work is part of your plan, say so early. Arrangements vary considerably by specialty.

Where to live in Christchurch

Christchurch is flat and gridded, so distance behaves predictably. Almost everywhere is within twenty minutes of work, which means you can choose on life rather than commute.

The real divide is east and west. The western suburbs are older, leafier, more sought-after for school zones and more expensive. The east, closer to the beaches, has seen a great deal of new building since the earthquakes and is markedly better value. Both have lovely places to live; the best way to choose is to spend a weekend driving around.

The second question is new build or character. A large share of the city's housing is less than fifteen years old. A new house in Halswell or Rolleston is warm, dry and cheap to run. A villa in Merivale has charm and history, and is worth checking for heating and insulation. Christchurch gives you a genuine choice between the two.

SUBURB	CHARACTER	SUITS	TO THE CENTRAL CAMPUS
Central city	Post-2011 apartments and townhouses	Couples, anyone who wants to live without a car	5 min
Addington	Workers' cottages and new infill	Registrars and nurses wanting a short commute at a good-value rent	6 min
Merivale	Established, leafy character homes	Senior clinicians and established families	8 min
Fendalton	Big trees, big houses, the strongest school zoning	Families making a long-term commitment	10 min
Cashmere	Elevated on the Port Hills, views to the Alps	Families who want a view and a garden	12 min
Halswell	Largely post-2011, fast-growing	Families wanting a modern, warm house	15 min
Sumner	A beach village with cliffs behind	Anyone who wants the sea at the end of the street	20 min

SUBURB	CHARACTER	SUITS	TO THE CENTRAL CAMPUS
Lyttelton	Hillside port town through the tunnel	People who want real character	18 min
Rolleston	Almost entirely new, full of young families	Families prioritising house size	30 min



Older villas and cottage gardens, full of character. Ask how a house is heated before you sign.



Lyttelton, over the hill from the city, with its own creative, harbourside character.

Every suburb has its own rhythm, and a few local tips help. Allow a little extra time on Riccarton Road, the city's busiest corridor. In hilly Cashmere, an e-bike is a happy investment. New Brighton offers the best-value coastal living of any New Zealand city, with a long beach, the pier and the hot pools. Lyttelton's tunnel has occasional maintenance closures, so check before a late trip.

Before you sign anything

- ☐ Ask when the house was built or repaired, and whether it is insulated and double glazed.
- ☐ With children, shortlist schools and check the zone maps first, then search for rentals inside them.
- ☐ Rent for six months before you buy. It is an easy way to learn whether you want the west, the hills or the coast.
- ☐ If you do buy, commission an engineer's report and read the insurance and repair history properly.

Getting around a flat, easy city

Christchurch is the flattest big city in New Zealand. After Auckland or Wellington, it feels wonderfully easy.

Most people drive, and driving here is easy. The grid means there is nearly always an alternative route, and parking outside the central city and the hospital campus is straightforward. Rush hour typically adds just five to ten minutes.

The city has invested heavily in separated cycleways over the past decade. The major routes feed into the centre and the hospital, and from most inner suburbs the ride is twenty to thirty minutes. With no hills, you arrive fresh for work. People who have not ridden a bike in twenty years end up commuting on one.

○ Suburb to central campus

15–25 MIN

From most suburbs by car. The satellite towns run twenty-five to forty.

○ Inner suburb by bike

20–30 MIN

Along separated cycleways for most of the way. On a nor'west day, allow a few extra minutes.

○ To the airport

10–15 MIN

The South Island's main hub, with direct flights to Australia, the Pacific and Singapore.

○ Arthur's Pass

~2 HRS

Alpine walking and the road over to the West Coast. The TranzAlpine train makes the same crossing.

○ Tekapo and the lakes

3 HOURS

Queenstown is about six.

The Metro bus network is reliable and good value, and a Metrocard makes it simple. Buses work well along the main corridors, and for cross-suburban trips a car or bike is often quicker. Most households keep a car, which is perfect for exploring the South Island.

Winter mornings bring frost from June to August. Keep a scraper in the car and allow an extra five minutes.

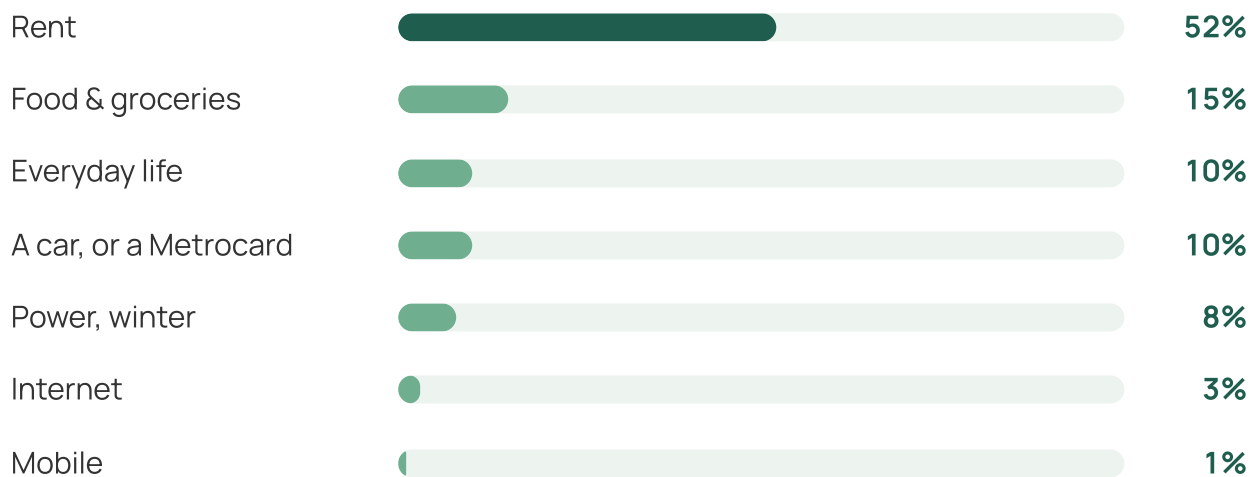
What it costs to live here

Christchurch is the best value of New Zealand's three main centres, and by a clear margin on housing. That extra breathing room is one of the city's great draws.

We do not print rents or monthly budgets, because figures date quickly. What stays true is the shape of a month, and a sense of which lines will surprise you.

Clinical pay sits on national collective agreements, so your gross salary here is identical to what it would be in Auckland or Wellington. What differs is what it buys.

Where a winter month goes



One person in an inner suburb, costed on winter power. Proportions, not amounts.

CHEAPER, SUBSTANTIALLY

Rent

The single largest difference. A family house in a good suburb costs well below the Auckland equivalent, and below Wellington too.

CHEAPER, SOMEWHAT

Power

Winters are colder, but so much housing is post-2011 and properly insulated that bills are often lower than in an older, draughtier home elsewhere.

CHEAPER, YES

Transport

Short commutes, no tolls and a genuine option to cycle. Many households run one car rather than two.

WORTH BUDGETING

Flights

Getting to Europe or North America means an extra leg, so plan the time and fare into your year.

Canterbury is prime farming country, so meat, dairy and seasonal produce are excellent. Imported goods carry a distance premium, as they do throughout New Zealand. Unfurnished usually means bringing your own fridge, washing machine and sometimes curtains, and second-hand whiteware from Trade Me is completely normal.

The largest thing to have ready on arrival is the bond and rent in advance, usually four weeks' bond plus two weeks' rent, before you have bought a kettle.

THREE THINGS TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Same national pay with the best-value big-city housing. The saving is concentrated almost entirely in rent or mortgage.
- ✓ Everyday costs sit around the national average. Budget a little more for groceries than you might expect, as across New Zealand.
- ✓ Budget for a winter power bill two to three times the summer one, and let insulation weigh heavily in your choice of house.



SOPHIE'S INSIGHTS

What I tell people about Christchurch

Christchurch is the move I recommend most often to families running the numbers. A tertiary caseload, a house you can actually afford, and the Alps for the weekend. On paper it can look like the sensible option; in person it turns out to be a great deal more than that.

Then they arrive. They find the commute gives them their evenings back, the house is warm, and their children are on a beach or a ski slope most weekends. People often tell me they love it far more than they expected. I have stopped being surprised.

My one piece of advice: come ready to enjoy a calmer pace than Auckland, and plan your trips home with an extra flight leg in mind. Do that, and it is very hard to beat.

Sophie Careem

Founder & Director, Ethicare Resourcing



Summer evenings in the garden: the part of the day families tell me they gained.



Christmas with friends: newcomer communities across New Zealand look out for one another.

Food, markets and city life

Christchurch eats from what Canterbury grows: some of the best raw ingredients in the country on its doorstep, and weekend markets that are genuine institutions.



The Terrace, the riverside strip that reopened the city centre after dark.

CENTRAL CITY

Riverside Market

A covered market hall of produce stalls, butchers, fishmongers and two floors of small kitchens. The best answer to "where should we go?"

ALONG THE RIVER

The Terrace

The closest Christchurch gets to a European promenade, and where the city goes on a warm evening.

INNER WEST

Riccarton Road

A solid kilometre of Korean, Chinese, Japanese, Malaysian and Vietnamese restaurants and grocers. The best-value eating in the city.

THROUGH THE TUNNEL

Lyttelton

Very good small restaurants and bars, and a Saturday farmers' market worth the drive on its own.

ON THE COAST

Sumner

Fish and chips on the sand, cafés along the esplanade, and a much-loved old cinema.

Coffee is good and taken seriously. Flat whites are the default, and every suburb has at least one café that roasts its own.

Most tastes from home are easy to find. Riccarton and the central city have halal butchers and South Asian grocers; Riccarton Road is the hub for East and South-East Asian supermarkets; and a growing set of African and Middle Eastern grocers sits mostly in the central and western suburbs. For the main shop, Pak'nSave is the cheapest of the big chains.



Weekend markets here are a genuine part of life rather than a tourist activity, and they are how a lot of newcomers first meet people.



Tūranga, the central library on Cathedral Square, is the rebuilt building people mention first.

Ngāi Tahu is the principal iwi of the South Island, and their history runs through the city's names, art and civic life. Names such as Ōtautahi and Ōtākaro are part of everyday use, not decoration.

Weekends in the mountains and by the sea

Ski fields ninety minutes away, surf beaches fifteen, and the whole South Island beyond that. This is the part people talk about most once they arrive.



Lyttelton Harbour from the Port Hills: the working port and the old volcanic crater.

Christchurch is the only city in New Zealand where skiing is an ordinary weekend rather than an annual holiday. Mt Hutt, the nearest field, is roughly ninety minutes from the western suburbs: leave at seven, ski all day, be home for dinner. The smaller club fields along the Arthur's Pass road are friendly, great-value rope-tow fields with a devoted following.

Fifteen to twenty minutes east you are at the coast. Sumner is the village with a beach. New Brighton has a long open beach, a pier and hot saltwater pools that opened after the earthquakes and are one of the best things in the city. Banks Peninsula is an hour or so away, with Akaroa, a harbour village founded by French settlers, at its heart.

EVERY WEEK

Saturday markets

Lyttelton's farmers' market, the market in the grounds of Riccarton House, and Riverside Market all week round.

CENTRAL CITY

Hagley Park & the Gardens

Picnics, park runs, cricket, punting on the Avon and the Botanic Gardens, all a short ride from most suburbs.

15–20 MIN

The Port Hills

Walking and mountain-bike tracks with views over the city and harbour, and a chairlift-served bike park.

15–20 MIN

Beach & hot pools

A swim or surf lesson at Sumner, then the hot saltwater pools at New Brighton.

ALL YEAR

Sport

Crusaders rugby in winter, cricket in summer, and club sport of every kind on Saturday mornings.

AROUND THE CITY

Days out with children

Orana Wildlife Park, Willowbank and the International Antarctic Centre, all on the airport side of town.

THROUGH THE YEAR

Festivals

The World Buskers Festival in summer, outdoor concerts in Hagley Park, and an arts festival in the rebuilt centre.



The Port Hills: walking and mountain-bike tracks along the city's southern edge.



Lake Tekapo, three hours inland. The Mackenzie Basin is a long-weekend habit.

Four favourite weekends

- ✓ Winter, active: Mt Hutt on Saturday, a slow Sunday at the Lyttelton market and a walk on the Port Hills.
- ✓ A long weekend: Hanmer Springs for the thermal pools, or Kaikōura for whales and crayfish.
- ✓ Summer, local: the beach at Sumner in the morning, the Botanic Gardens in the afternoon, dinner along the Terrace.
- ✓ The big one: the TranzAlpine over to Greymouth, or the drive to Tekapo and Aoraki.

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Winter driving tips

Between June and September the ski-field access roads regularly require chains. Keep a set in the car if you are heading for the snow.

If late nights out are high on your list, Christchurch keeps a gentler pace. If you love dinner on the Terrace, a film or a gig at an intimate venue, you will feel right at home. The real draw is a Saturday that starts in the mountains and finishes at the sea.



The heritage tram loops the central city. Visitors love it, and so do children.



Lyttelton Harbour on race day. Most weekends the water is yours.

Day trips and weekends around Canterbury

Christchurch sits at the start of the South Island's best road trips. Within an hour or two you can be on a volcanic peninsula, in a thermal pool or on a ski field.

Banks Peninsula rises straight out of the plains to the south-east: old volcanic harbours, quiet bays, rolling farmland and Akaroa, the harbour village founded by French settlers, about an hour and a half away. To the north, Waipara's vineyards are under an hour, Hanmer Springs' thermal pools under two, and Kaikōura's whales and seals around two and a half.

West, the road crosses the plains to Castle Hill and Arthur's Pass National Park, then over the Alps to the West Coast's rainforest and glaciers. South-west lie the Mackenzie Basin, Lake Tekapo and Aoraki / Mount Cook. And the rest of the country is close by air: Wellington and Auckland are short, frequent flights from the city's airport.

GETTING TO	ROUGHLY	WHY GO
Sumner & New Brighton beaches	15–20 min	Swimming, surf lessons, the pier and the New Brighton hot pools
Christchurch Airport	~15 min	The South Island's main hub, with direct flights to Australia and beyond
Mt Hutt ski field	~1 hr 30–2 hrs	The nearest large ski field, with beginner and family areas
Porters & the club fields	~1 hr 30–2 hrs	Smaller, friendly fields on the road to Arthur's Pass
Akaroa & Banks Peninsula	~1 hr 30	Harbour village, dolphin-watching cruises, bays and walks
Hanmer Springs	~1 hr 45	Thermal pools, forest walks and mountain biking
Arthur's Pass National Park	~2 hrs	Alpine walks, and the TranzAlpine train across the Alps
Kaikōura	~2 hrs 30	Whale watching, seals and crayfish where the mountains meet the sea
Lake Tekapo	~3 hrs	Turquoise water, hot pools and world-famous stargazing

GETTING TO	ROUGHLY	WHY GO
Wellington	~45 min flight	The capital: Te Papa, Zealandia and the waterfront
Queenstown	~6 hrs, or ~1 hr flight	Lakes, mountains and the Southern Lakes ski fields

~1 HR 30

Akaroa & the bays

French street names, harbour cruises to see Hector's dolphins, and quiet bays such as Okains on the far side of the peninsula.

~1 HR

Waipara Valley

North Canterbury wine country. Long lunches at cellar doors, an easy Sunday from the city.

~1 HR 15

Castle Hill / Kura Tāwhiti

Giant limestone boulders a short walk from the road to Arthur's Pass. A favourite with children and climbers alike.

~1 HR 45

Hanmer Springs

An alpine village built around hot pools, with forest walks and bike trails. The classic family weekend.

~2 HRS 30

Kaikōura

Whales, dusky dolphins and fur seals, with snow-capped ranges rising straight behind the coast.

~3-4 HRS

Tekapo & Aoraki / Mount Cook

Turquoise lakes, a dark-sky reserve, and the Hooker Valley track beneath the country's highest mountain.

~4-5 HRS

The West Coast

Over Arthur's Pass by car or on the TranzAlpine to rainforest, wild beaches and the Franz Josef and Fox glaciers.



Farmland above the harbours of Banks Peninsula, about an hour and a half from the city.



Franz Josef Glacier on the West Coast: a long weekend over the Southern Alps.



Lupins at Lake Tekapo in early summer, about three hours inland.

Schools and family life

Space, gardens, short commutes, beaches and hills close by, and a household budget that stretches further. Plan around school zoning and the rest falls into place.



Room to be outside is the thing families mention first.

Family life here is outdoors and unhurried. Hagley Park and the Botanic Gardens sit in the middle of the city, every suburb has parks and playgrounds, and the big Margaret Mahy Family Playground by the river is a weekend fixture. Flat streets and separated cycleways mean children learn to ride early, and short commutes mean parents are home for tea.

Saturday mornings belong to kids' sport: football, netball, rugby, cricket, hockey, swimming and more, run by local clubs that are also one of the quickest ways for newcomers to meet other parents.

What children tend to love here

- ✓ The Margaret Mahy Family Playground and the Botanic Gardens.
- ✓ Tūranga, the central library, with a whole floor of children's books, games and activities.
- ✓ Snow at Mt Hutt or Porters, ninety minutes to two hours away, from school age onwards.
- ✓ The beach at Sumner and the hot saltwater pools at New Brighton.
- ✓ Orana Wildlife Park, Willowbank and the International Antarctic Centre.

Schooling follows the national pattern. State schools are free at primary and secondary level, though most ask for a voluntary donation. State-integrated schools, often Catholic or other church schools, are government-funded with a special character and attendance dues. Independent schools charge fees. Children usually start school at five, and school is compulsory from six to sixteen.

Christchurch has the full range, including large, long-established state schools such as Christchurch Boys' and Christchurch Girls' High Schools, Burnside High and Cashmere High, integrated colleges such as St Bede's and Villa Maria, and independent schools including Christ's College, St Andrew's College, Rangī Ruru and St Margaret's College.



Shortlist schools first, check the zone maps, then search for rentals inside them. That order makes the search much easier.



School zones and reports

Popular state schools run enrolment schemes (zones): living inside the zone guarantees a place, so check the map before you sign a lease. The western suburbs, especially Fendalton and Ilam, hold the most sought-after zones, while Halswell and Rolleston have new schools to match their new houses. Read any school's Education Review Office report at ero.govt.nz.

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Early childhood and beyond

Kindergartens, playcentres and childcare centres are widespread, and the government funds up to 20 hours a week of early childhood education for three to five-year-olds. For later on, the city has the University of Canterbury, Lincoln University just outside the city, and Ara, the regional polytechnic.



Time on the water is an ordinary weekend here, not a holiday.



Bush walks are free, close and good for every age.

FOR FAMILIES, IN SHORT

- ✓ Short commutes mean more of the day with your children.
- ✓ Newer housing is warm and dry, which matters through a frosty winter.
- ✓ Beaches, the Port Hills and Hagley Park's 165 hectares are all close and free.
- ✓ Choose your school zone first, then your house.

“

A Saturday that starts in the mountains and finishes at the sea.

Your Christchurch address book

Christchurch has the South Island's largest migrant communities: an established Malayali association and a Malayalam Syro-Malabar mission, Mar Thoma and Indian Orthodox parishes, active Filipino and Pakistani groups, and its ethnic grocers are clustered around Riccarton, Sydenham and the central city.

COUNCIL AND CITY SERVICES

Christchurch City Council

Rubbish and recycling, rates, libraries, pools and building consents

ccc.govt.nz

Environment Canterbury

The regional council: air quality, water and the Metro bus network

ecan.govt.nz

Christchurch City Libraries

Tūranga and the suburban branches; free to join, with newcomer and language programmes

christchurchcitylibraries.com

GETTING AROUND

Metro

Bus routes, timetables and the Metrocard for Christchurch and Selwyn

metroinfo.co.nz

SETTLING IN AND EXPLORING

ChristchurchNZ

The city's official visitor and events guide, useful for the first few weekends

christchurchnz.com

Christchurch Art Gallery Te Puna o Waiwhetū

The city's public gallery, free to enter, with a busy programme of talks and family days

christchurchartgallery.org.nz

COMMUNITY & CULTURAL ASSOCIATIONS

Christchurch Kerala Association (CKANZ)

Christchurch's Malayali association, running since 2004: Onam, Christmas and family events for Keralites across Canterbury.

ckanz.org

Indian Social & Cultural Club

Long-running umbrella club for the Indian community; runs Christchurch's big public Diwali festival each October.

Pakistani Association Canterbury NZ (PACNZ)

Social, cultural and faith events for Pakistani families, and help for people relocating to Canterbury.

pacnz.com

Christchurch Multicultural Council

Member of the national federation of multicultural councils; behind the Culture Galore festival of 70+ cultures.

nzfmc.org.nz

Christchurch Resettlement Services

Free, confidential social work for migrants and refugees: housing, health, schools and interpreting.

03 335 0311 crs.org.nz

English Language Partners Christchurch

Free English classes, conversation groups, home tutoring and workplace English; Manchester St plus suburban classrooms.

03 377 3141 englishlanguage.org.nz/christchurch

PEETO The Multicultural Learning Centre

ESOL courses, cultural orientation and employment programmes for migrants and refugees.

New Zealand Newcomers Network

Coffee mornings and social events for people new to the area; find the Christchurch group on the site.

newcomers.co.nz

Citizens Advice Bureau

Free, confidential help with anything from tenancy to tax, with interpreters available.

0800 367 222 cab.org.nz

FACEBOOK & ONLINE GROUPS

Christchurch Kerala Association (Facebook)

Event news and notices for Christchurch's Malayali community.

facebook.com/p/Christchurch-Kerala-Association-100071808235085

Pinoy (Filipino) C.A.R.E.S Canterbury

Filipino community group for culture, sport, events and helping newcomers settle.

facebook.com/Pinoy-CARES-Canterbury-104593457957404

English Language Partners Christchurch (Facebook)

Class start dates and free conversation groups.

facebook.com/EnglishLanguagePartnersChristchurch

PLACES OF WORSHIP

Syro-Malabar Catholic Mission, Christchurch

Holy Mass in Malayalam every Sunday (2pm and 5pm), Saturday 9am and Friday 7pm, with catechism, at Sts Peter & Paul, 56 Nicholls Rd, Halswell.

syromalabarchristchurch.org.nz

Christchurch Mar Thoma Parish

Mar Thoma Syrian Church services in Malayalam at 275A Avonhead Rd; the parish serves the whole South Island.

christchurchmarthoma.org

St Mary's Indian Orthodox Church

Malankara Orthodox (Indian Orthodox) parish for Canterbury, based at 225 Kirk Rd, Templeton.

ChristChurch Transitional Cathedral (Anglican)

The 'Cardboard Cathedral' on Hereford St, the Anglican cathedral congregation since the earthquakes.

03 365 9444

Al Noor Mosque (Muslim Association of Canterbury)

The city's main mosque on Deans Avenue, Riccarton; daily and Friday prayers.

Linwood Islamic Centre

Mosque in the eastern suburbs on Linwood Avenue.

BAPS Shri Swaminarayan Mandir

Hindu temple at 19 Frank St, Papanui; open mornings and evenings daily.

03 354 6665

Hare Krishna Centre (ISKCON)

Temple at 83 Bealey Ave with a weekly Sunday feast and festivals.

harekrishnachristchurch.co.nz

Sri Ganesha Temple (Sri Ganesha Trust)

Hindu temple trust celebrating the main Hindu festivals in Christchurch.

Hindu Culture Centre, Hasketts Road

Hindu temple on the western edge of the city; a large new temple is being built nearby at Templeton.

Gurdwara Singh Sabha Christchurch

Gurdwara at 537 Ferry Rd, Woolston: daily prayers, weekend kirtan and langar, Punjabi classes for children.

Fo Guang Shan Buddhist Temple

Chinese Mahayana Buddhist temple in Riccarton, open to visitors.

Canterbury Hebrew Congregation

Synagogue at 406 Durham St with Shabbat services every week.

chc.org.nz

HALAL, KOSHER & INTERNATIONAL GROCERIES

Yogiji's Food Mart

Large Indian supermarket at 32 Wordsworth St, Sydenham, open 9am to 8pm daily.

03 372 3434 yogijis.co.nz

Spice Heaven

Indian and South Asian groceries and spices at 103 Stanmore Rd, Linwood.

facebook.com/spiceheavennz

Maihan Supermarket & Halal Meat

Halal butcher and Middle Eastern and Afghan grocer at 303 Colombo St.

MEFCO Middle Eastern Food Company

Middle Eastern groceries and halal products, Acheron Drive, Riccarton.

Riccarton Road Asian grocers

A kilometre of Chinese, Korean, Japanese and Filipino supermarkets: the place to start for Asian ingredients.

ChristchurchNZ halal food guide

The city's official list of halal-certified food shops, butchers and restaurants.

christchurchnz.com/wine-and-dine/halal-food-guide

Kosher food

No kosher shop locally; the Canterbury Hebrew Congregation is the best first contact for kosher sources.

chc.org.nz

SUPERMARKETS & MARKETS

Pak'nSave

The cheapest of the big chains, warehouse-style. Several large stores across the city; use the store finder for the nearest.

paknsave.co.nz/store-finder

Woolworths

Mid-range chain with the best online ordering and delivery. Stores in most suburbs.

woolworths.co.nz

New World

Slightly pricier, with a better fresh and speciality range. Stores across the city.

newworld.co.nz

Costco Northwood

Bulk buying for members, north of the city.

costco.co.nz

Riverside Market

Covered fresh-food market hall open seven days, corner of Lichfield St and Oxford Terrace.

riverside.nz

Christchurch Farmers' Market

Saturday mornings in the grounds of Riccarton House, with live music.

christchurchfarmersmarket.co.nz

Lyttelton Farmers' Market

Saturday mornings in the port town, the best for produce.

facebook.com/LytteltonFarmersMarket

Riccarton Rotary Sunday Market

The city's biggest Sunday market, at Riccarton Racecourse.

SCHOOLS, UNIFORMS & FAMILIES

Education Counts school finder

Find schools near an address and check which school zone a house falls in.

educationcounts.govt.nz/find-school

NZ Uniforms

Uniform stockist for many schools, with a Christchurch store; also check each school's own uniform shop and PTA second-hand sales.

nzuniforms.com

Plunket

Free health and development checks for under-fives, parent groups and PlunketLine advice (0800 933 922).

0800 933 922 plunket.org.nz

Playcentre

Parent-led early childhood centres and playgroups, good for meeting other families.

playcentre.org.nz

Christchurch City Libraries

Free libraries across the city with storytimes, holiday programmes, free wifi and books in many languages.

03 941 7923 my.christchurchcitylibraries.com

HOUSING & AREAS

Trade Me Property: Christchurch rentals

The main rental listings site; most landlords and agents list here.

trademe.co.nz/a/property/residential/rent/canterbury/christchurch-city

realestate.co.nz: Christchurch rentals

Second listings site, mainly agency-managed rentals.

realestate.co.nz/residential/rental/canterbury/christchurch-city

Tenancy Services market rent tool

Look up what similar homes actually rent for, by suburb and bedrooms.

tenancy.govt.nz/rent-bond-and-bills/market-rent

Christchurch City Council rates & valuation search

Check the rates and rating valuation for any address before you buy.

ccc.govt.nz/services/rates-and-valuations/rates-and-valuation-search

GETTING AROUND

Metro (Environment Canterbury)

Christchurch buses and the Diamond Harbour ferry; plan trips with the MetroGo journey planner.

metroinfo.co.nz

Motu Move and Metrocard

Pay fares with Motu Move or a contactless bank card or phone; Metrocard is being phased out.

metroinfo.co.nz

Christchurch Airport

Main South Island airport; Metro routes 3, 8, 29 and 125 run from the International Arrivals bus stand.

christchurchairport.co.nz

InterCity

Long-distance coaches linking South Island towns and cities.

intercity.co.nz

Great Journeys NZ

The TranzAlpine to the West Coast and Coastal Pacific to Picton (for the Cook Strait ferries).

greatjourneysnz.com

NZ Transport Agency (NZTA)

Converting an overseas licence, road rules and live road conditions.

nzta.govt.nz

AA

Licence tests and conversions, vehicle checks and roadside membership at AA centres.

aa.co.nz

COST OF LIVING COMPARISONS

Numbeo: Christchurch

Crowd-sourced prices to compare with your home city.

numbeo.com/cost-of-living/in/Christchurch

Expatistan: Christchurch

Another side-by-side cost comparison with cities worldwide.

expatistan.com/cost-of-living/christchurch

Powerswitch

Compare power and broadband plans for your address.

powerswitch.org.nz

Sorted

Free budgeting and money tools from the Retirement Commission.

sorted.org.nz

Stats NZ

Official prices, incomes and census data by area.

stats.govt.nz



Checked October 2026

Community groups, shops and pages change. If a link has moved or you know a group we should add, tell us and we will update the guide.

Numbers and websites to keep handy

The national services every newcomer uses, wherever in New Zealand you land.

EMERGENCIES & HEALTH ADVICE

Emergency services

Police, fire and ambulance, any time

111

Healthline

Free 24/7 health advice from a nurse, in any language

0800 611 116

Need to talk?

Free call or text a trained counsellor, 24/7

1737

National Poisons Centre

24/7 advice if someone may have been poisoned

0800 764 766

PlunketLine

Free 24/7 support for parents of under-fives

0800 933 922

VISAS, REGISTRATION & WORK

Immigration New Zealand

Visas, the Green List and residence pathways

immigration.govt.nz

Immigration Advisers Authority

Check an adviser is licensed before you pay

iaa.govt.nz

Responsible authorities

The registration board for every regulated health profession

health.govt.nz/regulated-health-professions

Nursing Council of New Zealand

Registration for nurses

nursingcouncil.org.nz

Medical Council of New Zealand

Registration for doctors

mcnz.org.nz

HEALTHCARE FOR YOUR FAMILY

Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora

How public healthcare works and who is eligible

tewhatuora.govt.nz

Healthpoint

Find a GP, pharmacy, dentist or urgent care near you

healthpoint.co.nz

ACC

Accident cover for everyone in New Zealand, including visitors

acc.co.nz

SCHOOLS & CHILDCARE

Find a school

Every school, with its enrolment zone

educationcounts.govt.nz/find-school

Education Review Office

Independent reports on schools and early learning

ero.govt.nz

Parents and whānau

How schooling, early childhood education and fees work

parents.education.govt.nz

MONEY, HOME & GETTING AROUND

Inland Revenue (IRD)

Your IRD number, tax and KiwiSaver
ird.govt.nz

Tenancy Services

Renting rules, bonds and market rents by area
tenancy.govt.nz

NZ Transport Agency

Converting your overseas driver licence
nzta.govt.nz/driver-licences

Powerswitch

Compare power companies in your area
powerswitch.org.nz

Sorted

Free, independent budgeting tools
sorted.org.nz

MPI · pets

Bringing cats and dogs into New Zealand
mpi.govt.nz/bring-send-to-nz/pets-travelling-to-nz

SETTLING IN

Citizens Advice Bureau

Free, confidential help with almost any question
0800 367 222 cab.org.nz

Ministry for Ethnic Communities

Support and connections for new migrant communities
ethniccommunities.govt.nz

Department of Conservation

Huts, tracks, campsites and Great Walks bookings
doc.govt.nz



Always check the source

Rules, fees and services change. Treat these as starting points and confirm details with the organisation. Ethicare are recruitment specialists, not licensed immigration advisers.

Six steps, and someone beside you for each one

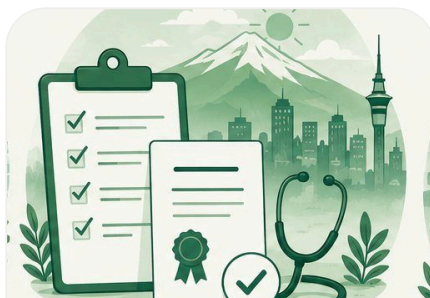
Moving country is a sequence of decisions. We take them with you in order, so you are never solving step five before step two is done.



STEP 1

Discovery call

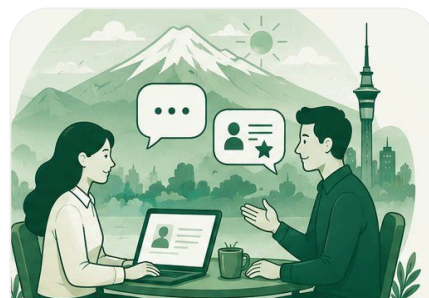
A relaxed conversation about your profession, your family and what you want from a move. No forms, no pressure.



STEP 2

Eligibility & registration

We map your route to New Zealand registration and help you gather the evidence the regulator will ask for.



STEP 3

Opportunities & interviews

Roles matched to where you want to live and how you like to work, with honest briefings before every interview.



STEP 4

Offer & decision support

We help you read the offer properly: pay step, relocation support, roster and what the team is really like.



STEP 5

Visa & relocation guidance

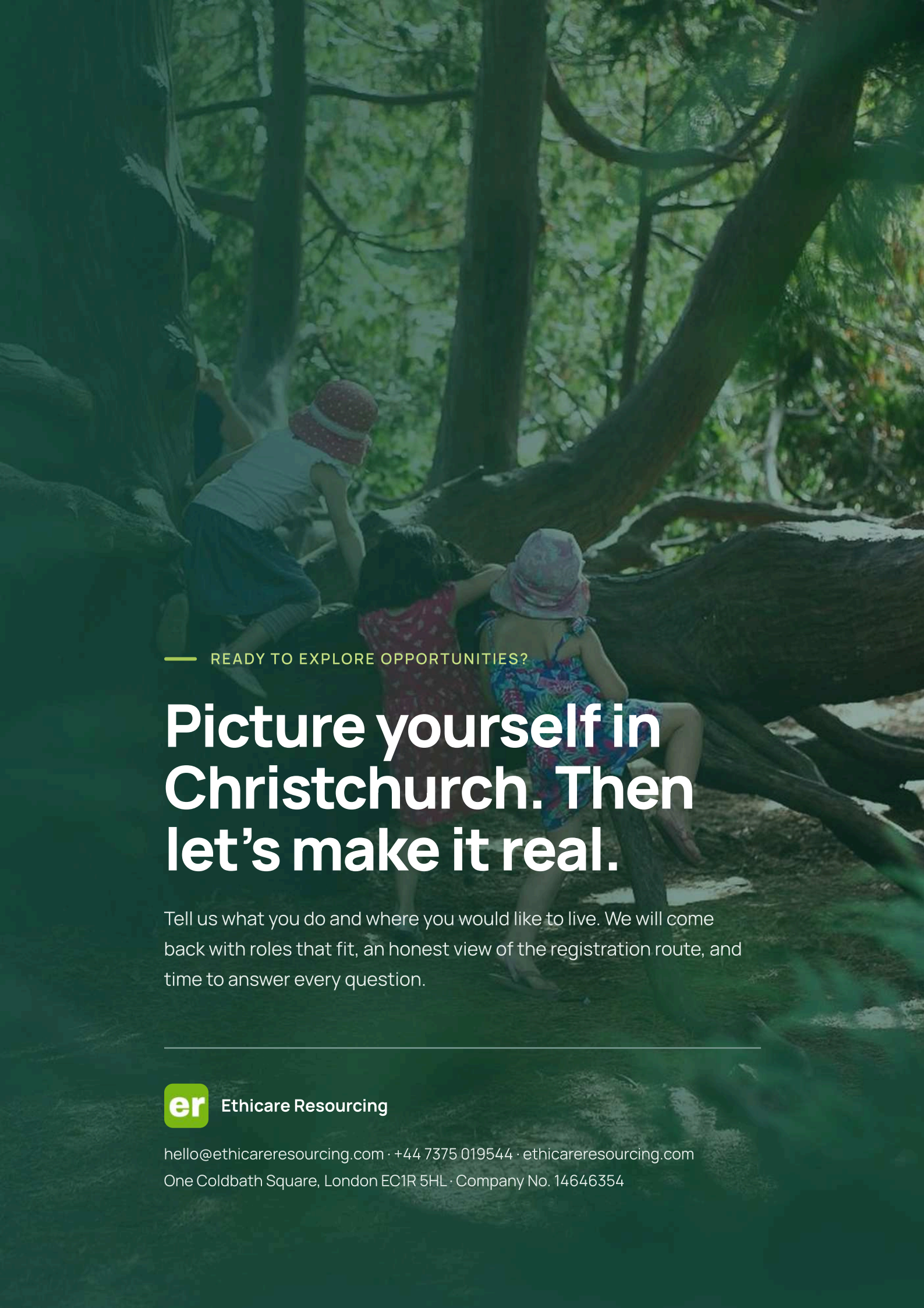
Practical guidance on visas, shipping, pets, schools and the first weeks, so nothing arrives as a surprise.



STEP 6

Settling in

We stay in touch after you land, from your first week on the ward to your first winter.

A photograph of three children climbing a large, fallen tree trunk in a forest. The children are wearing hats and casual clothing. The scene is dappled with sunlight and shadows from the surrounding trees.

— READY TO EXPLORE OPPORTUNITIES?

Picture yourself in Christchurch. Then let's make it real.

Tell us what you do and where you would like to live. We will come back with roles that fit, an honest view of the registration route, and time to answer every question.



Ethicare Resourcing

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